



▲ **A block rake train** loads iron ore for TISCO at Gorumahisani, Odisha, from the nearby mines.

Beginning of change

Canadian historian Ian J Kerr notes two key innovations in freight transportation in independent India. One lay in enhancing capacity equipment and the other in improving policies and practices.

In a major policy change, a uniform rate structure was implemented in 1948, which has since been continuously improved and simplified to provide better services to customers. Equipment change entailed hopper cars, tanker wagons, rail flat cars, and units with improved technology, such as refrigeration and air brakes. In the mid-1960s, the introduction of containerization revolutionized the way freight moved. It not only integrated road and rail transportation, but also provided speedy and safer services for freight.

The early 1980s saw another significant change, under the Railway Board chairman MS Gujral. During this time, homogenous wagons were linked together, reducing the time taken in train formation and increasing